

Over 4.38 million Ukrainians remain under temporary protection in the EU, while security concerns and host-country support remain primary barriers to return. Canada has ended special immigration measures, narrowing diaspora reactivation pathways. Retaining talent inside Ukraine is increasingly urgent as bombardment casualties mount and female labor participation remains structurally suppressed.

Security is the dominant variable: until frontline risk decreases, neither return incentives nor recruitment programs can fully compensate for ongoing displacement of 4.38M+ Ukrainians abroad.

RETURN

IOM: Reintegration Barriers Block Mass Return

IOM's August 2026 report finds 4.38M Ukrainians hold EU temporary protection. Key return barriers include housing destruction, lack of jobs, and security fears. Reintegration outcomes vary sharply by region and household vulnerability, requiring targeted policy rather than blanket incentives.

3R: Directly maps reintegration failure points; informs Return pillar program design for housing, employment, and psychosocial support.

Migration Policy Institute: Security & Jobs Drive Return Intent

Survey of ~61,000 Ukrainians shows security conditions, host-country support levels, and job availability are the three decisive factors shaping return or stay decisions, reinforcing circular migration patterns rather than permanent resettlement.

3R: Quantifies levers for Return programs; job-matching and safety guarantees are highest-ROI interventions for diaspora reactivation.

MIGRATION POLICY INSTITUTE

Canada Ends Special Ukraine Immigration Measures

As of April 1, 2026, Canada's special immigration pathways for Ukrainians have changed, reducing facilitated entry options. This may redirect some diaspora toward Ukraine return, but also risks stranding vulnerable populations with uncertain status.

3R: Policy window: Ukrainians losing Canadian status are a prioritized Return cohort requiring outreach and reintegration support.

GOVERNMENT OF CANADA

RECRUIT

73% of Unemployed Ukrainian Women Want to Work

VoxUkraine analysis reveals 73% of jobless Ukrainian women are willing to work but face structural barriers including childcare deficits, discrimination, and legal gaps. New draft legislation aims to strengthen labor market inclusion for women.

3R: Massive untapped domestic talent pool; targeted recruitment into skill-gap sectors (tech, healthcare, logistics) can offset brain drain without relying on diaspora return.

VOXUKRAINE

Brain Drain Economics: Diaspora as Recruitment Asset

Academic research identifies four brain-drain offsets: remittances, induced education investment, return migration, and diaspora network effects. For Ukraine, diaspora professionals can be recruited as remote contributors, advisors, or returnee specialists before full physical return.

3R: Theoretical framework for Recruit pillar: diaspora engagement programs deliver value even before physical return via remote work and knowledge transfer.

RESEARCHGATE / ACADEMIC

RETAIN

Escalating Bombardment Accelerates Internal Displacement

In July 2026 alone, 437 Ukrainian civilians were killed and 2,610 injured. Sustained Russian aerial bombardment drives internal displacement and pushes skilled workers to relocate abroad, directly undermining talent retention in war-affected regions.

3R: Core Retain threat: physical security is prerequisite for any retention strategy; employers in frontline oblasts need remote-work and relocation support frameworks.

ATLANTIC COUNCIL

IOM GPS Round 23: Regional Population Retention Profiles

IOM's 23rd General Population Survey (May 2026) provides oblast-level data on displacement intentions, return plans, and livelihood status. Regional variation is significant, enabling targeted retention interventions in oblasts with high outmigration risk.

3R: Granular data asset for Retain programs; enables prioritization of high-risk oblasts for livelihood support and employer incentive schemes.

IOM DTM

GLOBAL CONTEXT

World Migration Report 2026: 856,800 Ukrainians Granted Protection in 2024

IOM's flagship report confirms 856,800 Ukrainians received international protection in 2024, predominantly in the EU. Ukraine remains the world's largest forced displacement crisis, shaping global migration policy debates and donor priorities.

3R: Macro baseline for all 3R planning; scale of displacement underscores urgency of coordinated Return, Recruit, and Retain strategies.

IOM WORLD MIGRATION REPORT 2026

UNHCR Moldova: Population Movement Visualization 2022–2026

UNHCR Moldova documents population flows from Ukraine over four years using official border data, illustrating circular migration patterns and the scale of regional displacement across Moldova and neighboring states.

3R: Regional context for Return programming; Moldova corridor data helps identify circular migrants as near-term returnee candidates.

UNHCR MOLDOVA

JNS Opinion: Competition for Ukrainian Jewish Diaspora

An Israeli advocacy piece urges Ukrainian Jews to repatriate to Israel rather than Germany or Poland, highlighting geopolitical competition for diaspora communities. This illustrates how multiple states actively recruit Ukraine's educated diaspora segments.

3R: Signals diaspora competition: Ukraine must actively counter third-country recruitment of skilled diaspora with compelling return value propositions.

JEWISH NEWS SYNDICATE
